

path, we decided to try another MVP. We used a simple hack, which felt almost like cheating. We changed the product so that customers could click where they wanted their avatar to go, and the avatar would teleport there instantly. No walking, no obstacle avoidance. The avatar disappeared and then reappeared an instant later in the new place. We couldn't even afford fancy teleportation graphics or sound effects. We felt lame shipping this feature, but it was all we could afford.

You can imagine our surprise when we started to get positive customer feedback. We never asked about the movement feature directly (we were too embarrassed). But when asked to name the top things about IMVU they liked best, customers consistently listed avatar "teleportation" among the top three (unbelievably, they often specifically described it as "more advanced than The Sims"). This inexpensive compromise outperformed many features of the product we were most proud of, features that had taken much more time and money to produce.

Customers don't care how much time something takes to build. They care only if it serves their needs. Our customers preferred the quick teleportation feature because it allowed them to get where they wanted to go as fast as possible. In retrospect, this makes sense. Wouldn't we all like to get wherever we're going in an instant? No lines, no hours on a plane or sitting on the tarmac, no connections, no cabs or subways. Beam me up, Scotty. Our expensive "real-world" approach was beaten handily by a cool fantasy-world feature that cost much less but that our customers preferred.

So which version of the product is low-quality, again?

MVPs require the courage to put one's assumptions to the test. If customers react the way we expect, we can take that as confirmation that our assumptions are correct. If we release a poorly designed product and customers (even early adopters) cannot figure out how to use it, that will confirm our need to invest in superior design. But we must always ask: what if they don't care about design in the same way we do?

Thus, the Lean Startup method is not opposed to building high-